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US Rates Strategy

Are buybacks catching a cold or a fever?

CITI'S TAKE

The market appeared disappointed with today's 10y-20y buyback announcement of \$6bn maximum for tomorrow's liquidity support operation. However, we remain long 20y bonds and think the Treasury Secretary's UST 'put' should be taken seriously. The market may be overreacting to the updated schedule, which still states future sizes will be ">=4bn," but we think \$6bn will be the operational minimum for the remainder of this cycle.

Today Treasury announced tomorrow's 10y to 20y buyback operation would have a maximum amount of \$6bn. This is above the \$4bn minimum which Treasury announced a few weeks ago (see [US Rates Strategy - Getting long 20y after today's buyback announcement](#)). Following today's announcement, 30y yields moved up ~5bp and are back at levels last seen when Treasury announced the increased buybacks. The fact that there is a 30y auction tomorrow, and an expectation for continued IG supply post Labor Day, may have helped fuel a stronger reaction today. Still, the market likely expected \$8bn for the buyback operation announced today. However, we think the selloff today may be more related to the Treasury's updated buyback schedule than tomorrow's operation.

In the updated published schedule, Treasury reported that future long-end buybacks will be ">=4bn" as opposed to \$6bn. But we would not have expected Treasury to rephrase their commitment to be at a minimum of \$6bn. Going forward, we believe today's announcement can be taken as a future minimum. This is sizeable especially if the 20y-30y operation is also expanded to \$6bn (which is now our base case). On a quarterly run rate, that implies \$48bn of long-end buybacks, which is 43% of the \$111bn gross 20y and 30y quarterly supply. In some sense, this is effectively already ending the 20y bond, of which Treasury issues \$42bn per quarter, but the market appears unconvinced.

Our long conviction rests on our view that the Treasury 'put' should strengthen if yields move north of 5.3%. This week, Treasury Secretary Bessent stated he was happy to push yields "back towards equilibrium". While he does not believe he can "change the equilibrium price", we think shorts will struggle to test well north of 5.3% especially after it appears the Treasury Secretary got his way with USDJPY. In our view, the Treasury Secretary must focus on supply and buybacks given the Iran conflict, via higher oil, is still driving yields. This sets the November refunding, with the next dealer survey to be released on October 16, as a potentially bullish catalyst. We think all options are on the table for Treasury and most paths lead to less 20y supply. We continue to like the 20y point both outright and on a relative value basis

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With thanks to
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(96-10 as of 1pm on 9/9/2026, see [US Rates Strategy - Getting long 20y after today's buyback announcement](#)). We also remain in 10s20s spreads steepeners (-24bp as of 1pm on 9/9/2026, see [US Rates Weekly - March showers bring April rallies?](#)).

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